SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #120 · THE END TIMES

# “Natural disasters are God punishing the people they strike.”

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## Where it often comes from

Public figures who blame disasters on the sins of certain groups. Teaching that every tragedy is a direct judgment. Trying to make sense of devastating events. Fear that a disaster in your life means God is angry with you. Confusing the general brokenness of creation with specific punishment.

## What Scripture teaches

God is sovereign over creation, and Scripture records some specific judgments. But Jesus directly rejected the idea that victims of disasters are worse sinners. When a tower fell and killed eighteen people, He said they were not more guilty than others. The whole creation is groaning under the effects of sin, and God sends sun and rain on the righteous and the unrighteous alike. Disasters remind all of us of our need for God, and they call us to compassion, not judgment, toward those who suffer.

> *“Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem? No, I tell you. But unless you repent, you too will all perish”* **(Luke 13:4–5)**.

## Also see

> “That you may be sons of your Father in heaven. He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous” **(Matthew 5:45)**.

> “We know that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until the present time” **(Romans 8:22)**.

> “The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance” **(2 Peter 3:9)**.

> “And the One seated on the throne said, ‘Behold, I make all things new.’ Then He said, ‘Write this down, for these words are faithful and true.’” **(Revelation 21:5)**.

## Common self-statements

- Those people must have deserved it.
- God sent that disaster to punish them.
- If a disaster hits me, God is angry with me.
- Tragedies always mean judgment.
- I can tell who God is punishing by what happens to them.
- Victims should examine what they did wrong.

## Common logical errors

- **Jumping to conclusions:** Deciding the cause of a disaster without God’s revelation.

- **Judgmental thinking:** Assuming victims are worse sinners.
- **Personalization:** Seeing a disaster in your own life as proof of God's anger.
- **Ignoring Jesus' teaching:** Overlooking His direct words in Luke 13.

## Challenging questions

- What did Jesus say about the eighteen who died when the tower fell?
- Were they worse sinners than others?
- What does Matthew 5:45 say about sun and rain?
- Why is all of creation groaning, according to Romans 8:22?
- What does God want, according to 2 Peter 3:9?
- Does this belief make me more compassionate or more judgmental?
- How can I help people affected by disasters?

## Truth summary

> Natural disasters are not proof that God is punishing the people they strike. Jesus said the victims of tragedy were not worse sinners than others. All creation groans under sin's effects, and disasters touch the righteous and unrighteous alike. They remind all of us of our need for God and call me to compassion, prayer, and help.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Disaster
- Suffering
- Judgmental
- Love, For Others
- End Times

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Natural disasters are God punishing the people they strike"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

**Name:** _____ **Date started:** _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

**"Natural disasters are God punishing the people they strike."** I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What did Jesus say about the tower's victims?
- ☐ Were they worse sinners?
- ☐ What does Matthew 5:45 say?
- ☐ Why is creation groaning?
- ☐ What does God want for everyone?
- ☐ Does this belief make me compassionate or judgmental?

**My own question:** _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Disaster victims are not worse sinners than others.
- ☐ All creation groans under sin's effects.
- ☐ God sends sun and rain on everyone.
- ☐ Disasters remind all of us of our need for God.
- ☐ I am called to compassion, not judgment.
- ☐ God will one day make all things new.

**In my own words:** _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- [ ] **Luke 13:4–5**
  *"Or those eighteen who were killed when the tower of Siloam collapsed on them: Do you think that they were more sinful than all the others living in Jerusalem? No, I tell you. But unless you repent, you too will all perish."*
- [ ] **Matthew 5:45**
  *"That you may be sons of your Father in heaven. He causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous."*
- [ ] **Romans 8:22**
  *"We know that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until the present time."*
- [ ] **2 Peter 3:9**
  *"The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance."*
- [ ] **Revelation 21:5**
  *"And the One seated on the throne said, 'Behold, I make all things new.' Then He said, 'Write this down, for these words are faithful and true.'"*

**A verse I found myself:** _____

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# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Compassion log:** Each day, pray for people affected by a disaster or hardship, and write one way I can help.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 2 Peter 3:9 becomes: "The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with **Sarah**, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Disaster" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio download.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- ☐ **Read Luke 13:1–5,** and write what Jesus said about tragedy and repentance.
- ☐ **Give or volunteer to help people affected by a disaster** this month.
- ☐ **When you hear someone blame victims,** gently share Jesus' words in Luke 13.
- ☐ **If a disaster has affected you,** talk with a pastor or counselor about your fears and losses.

**What I will do:** _____

**When:** _____

**What the lie predicts will happen:** _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

**What actually happened:** _____

**What I learned:** _____

**The lie** "Natural disasters are God punishing the people they strike": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | One act of compassion |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Natural disasters are God punishing the people they strike.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, my heart breaks when disasters strike. Help me reject the lie that natural disasters are You punishing the people they strike. Give me compassion instead of judgment, move me to help those who suffer, and fill me with hope that You will make all things new. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

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*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*